

Theatre in Digital Era as a Medium of Cultural Exchange as Exemplified in Selected Online Contents

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Abstract

The digital era has created an atmosphere where dramatic activities engage the internet on a daily basis. It has avail people the opportunity to explore online contents within the comfort of their homes. In Nigeria, online contents on various subject matters have sustained the interest of the teeming audiences of social media. There has been pockets of performances, showcasing various cultural practices, values and beliefs in Nigerian. Foster cultural understanding, there are performances that portray negative stereotype and misleading information. Despite the enormous opportunities in the digital space, theatre practitioners have not adequately explored the digital space as a pivotal platform to promote theatrical performances, as well as indigenous cultural ethos for global connectivity and appreciation. As a result, the significance of such creative productions is grossly undermined. Adopting Stuart Hall's theory of Cultural Identity, this paper uses the content analysis and observation methods to examine four online contents selected from the southern, eastern, western and northern regions of Nigeria to showcase their cultural relevance and how that could influence and facilitate cultural exchange. It is observed that digital media is a veritable resource for cultural cross-fertilisation. In addition, by annexing digital media, theatre practitioners would stir waves of national cultural awareness, tolerance and dignity among Nigerians. It recommends that theatre artists engage popular social media platforms, especially YouTube, Facebook, Instagram, TikTok and WhatsApp more regularly to be relevant in a competitive digital era. It concludes that dramatic performances have shifted focus from the traditional to the digital stage and the digital media has become the new hub for cultural exchange.

Keywords: Theatre, Cultural Exchange, Digital Era, Online Contents, Social Media

Introduction

There has been steady innovations as regards to space and style in which dramatic performances are rendered in Nigeria. Theatre spaces have been evolving in many ways right from the days of the popular Alarinjo travelling theatre and the Ogunde theatre of the South western Nigeria of the 1960s to the development of the Nigerian movie industry in the mid 1990's. (Azeez 175, Ayakoroma 14). The changes in the spaces are necessitated by the need to satisfy the audience and the response to technological advancement. This explains the craze with the digital theatre in the 21st Century. Digital theatre serves as an interactive platform that provides numerous communication channels, such as Facebook, WhatsApp, Instagram, Telegram, and others, to meet the varied needs of members of the society. Unlike radio and television, the internet allows for quick and effective communication between people, making it easy to get feedback

promptly. Digital theatre has transformed not only stagecraft but dramaturgy, audience participation, as well as performance reception. (Sharma 59)

Apparently, the design of social media encompasses a broad spectrum of activities in comparison to those occurring within our immediate surroundings. On a daily basis, multitudes of users could access their desired content simultaneously, circumventing the need for queuing. In the same vein, one cannot rule out the reality that the digital theatre also has its limitations of internet connectivity and electricity among other factors; for a digital presence. The point the researcher is making is that, digital theatre is a veritable medium to portray factual cultural history, if not left for people without requisite knowledge to explore. Today, performances from different regions in Nigeria; featuring the nation's rich cultural elements exists on the internet for people to learn from cultures other than their own.

Today, it is well-established and accepted fact that organizations of any kind need to be part of and embrace digital transformation, otherwise they cannot strive and succeed in the digital society we live in. for that to happen, organizational culture needs to reshape and be innovative in order to welcome and accommodate all the shifts that digital transformation brings about (Serpa, Sa, & Ferreira, 31)

The digital media does not just promote theatrical productions but it serves as an important space where knowledge of a people's culture is transmitted. If an online content is on the Ijaw worldview, it goes on to provide practices peculiar to Ijaw people for global appreciation. It is this practice that provide meaning in the broader context to the society at large. The essential point here is that the content offers a dramatisation of a particular culture, with narratives which may have been earlier misunderstood.

Theoretical Framework

The paper adopts Stuart Hall's theory of Cultural Identity propounded in 1990. Hall, postulated in Yang, Zhao and Liu's work that cultural identity entails collective identity; one that reflect on the past (178). This theory calls for collaborative actions as it brings people to gather and give them a sense of oneness by exposing them to the essentialities of culture. The theory holds that what makes a people who they are, is the cultural identity. The language, belief, norms and values, and all daily activities that make life worthwhile for them. This theory focuses on a people's original ethnic culture and how individuals or groups use communicative processes to project their cultural identity in an exceptional perspective in their storyline, which is an accurate reflection of the culture. Hall states that culture is one of the numerous identities displaced in communication encounters. Communication encounters include the use of performances to express cultural and historical legacies and enable individuals to assess their culture in relation to others seen. Dwelling specifically on the fact that the theatre is one major mediums of depicting the cultural values of a people, this study will use the perspective of this theory to examine the role of theatre in facilitating cultural exchange in the digital era. The theory deals with all human endeavours or activities in consonance with every societal rule and regulation of any given race. Such as ceremonial activities, ritual performances, hunting of animals, theatrical shows, cinematic orchestrations, dramas and other endeavours, like games, sports, plays, scripts, dances, music, historical events, artistic performances and speculative

ideas. The theory is relevant to this study as it qualifies online content as theatrical performances in this digital era.

Theatre in the Digital Era

Theatre in a digital era simply means theatre and internet connectivity. It means the practice of employing electronic networking in performance practice. Reflecting on this, we can say that theatre has a digital presence and has used technology to address salient issues happening in society. This interconnectivity between theatre and technology has influenced theatre practice largely and has facilitated cultural exchange. It has created a new kind of interaction between performers, spectators and their activities. It has created artistic contents in diverse ways. This has greatly advanced theatrical productions in the different aspects of theatre like set design, acting, choreography, directing and so on. Pre-digitalism, the traditional live performances were strictly enacted in front of the audience. The development of theatre in the age of technology characterises one of the most momentous transformations in contemporary performance culture. Digital technologies have expanded theatrical language, redefined audience engagement, and created advanced forms of immersive storytelling (Sharma 60) In fact performers move from place to place during the popular theatre performances in search of their audiences. There was always a need for actors and audience connection in any performance thus; audience presence was of great significance.

The interaction with audience through eye contacts and gestures were core aspects of entertainment. However, the invention of new media performances transcends the physical gathering for live performances; which was highly restrictive and audience have multiplied in number.

With the impact of digital technologies on theatre performances, comes the transition. Digital media has taken performance beyond the limits of the physical gathering by shifting its core performance space to a more accessible and inclusive space. Members of society can now watch as many live performances as they wish to in the comfort of their homes. Thus, it allows the opportunity of having new audiences in every live-streamed performance. This has helped to globally transmit the message of change theatre preaches in its performances, most especially in places where the culture of theatre going is considered insignificant. The new technology makes it possible on a daily basis for people to see performances from different cultures of the society as long as there is data in their phones, thereby ensuring a progressive history of theatre in the world. Thus, it is opines that:

Digital theatre is rather to be seen as an essential part of the progressive history of modern or contemporary experimental theatre whose relevance is not necessarily an alternative theatre, but an essential part of the history of the growing body of universal theatre. A tool upon which it leverages is new technological apparatuses to sustain and preserve the culture of theatre making and theatre going. (Ododo 11)

People watch performances right on their sick beds and enjoy momentary relieve from their disturbing situations. Interestingly, medical experts have also confirmed that performances are

therapeutic to ailing patients. The relevance of new media touches its alternative form of performance but most essentially its sustainability of theatre culture globally. Apart from audience engagement and accelerated performances which is an obvious reality that technology brings to theatre. The digital theatre has expanded creativity. The use of technology has enabled directors and technical designers to produce complex works of art with less effort. It has also enhanced theatrical experience on the area of productions. It has influenced production concepts and styles.

Currently, theatre productions integrate digital tools to visual set designs; this enables the creation of believability and allows intricate effects that cannot be easily achieved with manual props and sets designs on stage. Theatre productions can use 3D printings and projections to transform the stage to a living canvas with projected imageries; creating entirely new visual atmosphere. “For instance 3D animated sets can visually mix the real and the imagined places or the stage and the scene, where movement becomes integrated into the visual spectacle in seemingly natural ways or fantasy”. (Boh & Adoka 34)

Another aspect is the lighting and sound systems of theatrical productions. As theatre evolves through the help of technology, the lighting and sound systems of productions have also experienced sophistication with significant advancements. Instead of the manual light changes to create mood and atmosphere, the lights can be pre-programmed to change at intervals, dimmed or brightened when necessary with the required colour effect. In a live-streamed performance, transition from one scene to another is seamlessly done and the dramatic effect is overwhelming. Just by clicking on a single button on the console, automatically, transition occurs in a timely, precise and effective manner. Technology has introduced digital soundboards that handle audio related sounds to reduce errors of background noise during live performances. It gives a serene environment with good acoustic system.

Beyond technology impacting on the technical aspects of theatre and how it enhances theatrical productions due to its flexibility in connecting to the world, it is arguable that “digital tools are mainly instruments of theatre making...” (Ododo 10) we would agree that it has added theatre to stir waves of national cultural awareness, tolerance and dignity among Nigerians. Of course going by how people from different parts of the world connect daily; they share and learn from one another's cultures. Through cross-cultural fertilisation, people gain cultural insight worldwide.

Cultural Exchange through Digital Theatre

Digital theatre through performance art promotes global understanding of cultures of the world. “The convergence of theatre with new media has led to this social and cultural activities taking place online...” (Kumar, Chaturvedi and Merhotra 2). It has popularised cultural practices, values, traditions, dresses patterns, food, laws and beliefs of various ethnicities for cross-cultural relationship. For instance a theatre production done in Bayelsa State of Nigeria can be seen by spectators all over world within seconds of the performance. As such, geographical limitations are overcome and avenues for cultural exchange are opened up. Viewers can learn about Bayelsa cultural art without necessarily travelling down to Bayelsa State. Through this avenue the distinctive aspects of Ijaw people is showcased for others to learn from. This is the aim of any cultural piece seen on the public space, to provide the cultural background of its

people to the world. The primary focus is to gain visibility and protect their rich cultural artistry. This is not peculiar to the Ijaws of Bayelsa or the Niger Delta Region; it cuts across all ethnic groups who understand the role of the digital theatre in cultural exchange. Speaking on trends in 20th century, it is expressed that:

Another trend that began in the 20th century was the globalization of theatre. As transportation and communication technology improved, the inevitable encounters with other cultural and socio-political influences on theatre happened. The result is that during the latter part of the 20th century there was a growth in the cross-cultural exchange of ideas, products and services, languages, and art across the world of theatre. These ideas are shared across all cultures east to west and north to south. (Zahi 12)

In essence, our shared cultural experiences and values are instrumental for cultural exchange. When various cultures intersect there is always cross-cultural exchange. Particularly in Nigeria where there are diverse cultures and ethnicities, social media has contributed to building mutual cultural respect amongst its citizens and has brought about a blend in artistry through collaborative creative initiatives in arts and crafts, cuisines, dresses, and other cultural heritages. These cultural ideas are not new to Nigerians because they are not new to the digital platforms. They have been successfully reflected in online content which have created awareness, provided a sense of belonging and inspired groups to come together in unity to portray and celebrate their cultural narratives (Adie, Okoro & Orim online). We have to be at home with the fact that online dramatic and cultural content portray the image of the society they are generated from and the representation largely determines how a certain culture is seen throughout the world. Thus, it is important that content creators do portray a true imagery of their society. If there is cultural misrepresentation it perpetuate a negative stereotype about the people and their culture.

Analysis and Interpretation of Online Contents as Mechanisms for Cultural Exchange

Online content is from the identified subjects that will captivate the intended audience, followed by the strategic development, production, and dissemination of material pertaining to such subjects. The significance of content lies in its ability to efficiently attract and guide individuals through differing marketing funnels. Social media content production refers to the process of generating and disseminating information and pictures on various social media platforms. Every social media platform has its own guidelines on the optimal material to publish, the maximum length of captions, the proper use of hashtags, and the recommended dimensions for images or videos. Creating material for social media is a distinct kind of art. In order to thrive, social media content producers must possess a comprehensive understanding of the criteria established by each social media platform, as well as the most effective sorts of material.

Social media content production may be classified into several categories. We have text posts, which provide fundamental textual entries. This entails just a written caption or text status (perhaps accompanied by a few emoticons). Images and graphics are a widely favoured kind of content. Collaborating with others to produce such assets may be a valuable approach for your social media team. However, it is also beneficial for social media managers to possess

fundamental photography and graphic design abilities. Image carousels are an excellent method for simultaneously sharing many images on social media. These images are swipeable and on Instagram, they transition smoothly, allowing for simple connection between each picture.

Virtually, all social media platforms encourage and promote the dissemination of photographs. It is an excellent method to include visual elements into your written pieces. Again, videos are now an immensely popular kind of social media material, and they are highly favoured by social media site algorithms. Video material is ubiquitous across many social media platforms. Extended video material is effective on your YouTube channel, as well as platforms such as LinkedIn and Facebook. The focus of the present research is mostly on the videos found in social media platforms, with particular emphasis on cultural exchange.

Data analysed were selected primarily from online content. Sources are mainly TikTok and YouTube, which provides the information required for the discourse. Four online skits selected from the eastern, western, northern and southern regions of Nigeria are analysed in line with the subject of digital theatre fostering cultural exchange.

Ijaw Drama Skit: The story is centred on “Igbada”. It is an ancient cultural practice of the Ijaws to worship their ancestors and for consultations during burial ceremonies. The Igbada is a wooden structure in form of a ladder carried by 4 men which controls their movements and action. The first step of this ceremony is called “worudosu”, which is serving of drinks by the Igbada to the ancestors. Igbada pours the drink on the ground in worship of his ancestors. If the ceremony is for the dead, if it's a male, then the Teinbiwei will call the name of the dead person 3 times but if a female, the name will be called 4 times in the presence of the Igbada as a form of consultation with the ancestors. It is believed that if the cause of a person's death is not natural, the factor responsible will be revealed. Thereafter, other events like singing, dancing and dramatic wrestling will be done between men and women to crown the ceremony before the dead will be laid to rest.

From this drama skit, an aspect of the culture of the Ijaws is reflected. It captures their belief in their ancestors in the quest for truth; a belief system that is typically centred on promoting decorum and morality in their society. This maybe doubted by others who are non Ijaws, but it has been proven to be a reliable method of finding out secret things from the spiritual realm. This Ijaw drama which could possibly be seen in the rural communities only, can now be viewed by the entire world at the same time on social media. Meaning, it was an experience only those in the villages can tell but with technological inventions, it has been documented and enacted as a dramatic action. For instance, I didn't have to go down to any Ijaw community to gather this information because it is right there on social media, made possible by technology.

Yoruba Drama Skit: The story was uploaded by Wode-Maye on TikTok. It is centred on festival drama. It tells the story of the Yoruba Egungen festival. This performance was done by Yorubas in Diaspora; Trinidad Tobago. They carried the Yoruba culture of Nigeria with them, even though they were far away in another country. The festival portrays the people's annual ritual of celebrating their ancestral night in honour of their late ancestors. The story also reveals that during the slave trade in the Caribbean, the Yoruba people were more of the people that settled in Trinidad. Be that as it may, their long years in Trinidad could have eroded their knowledge of the Yoruba culture but they never lose track of their identity. It was clearly portrayed that their

culture is their identity. This was reflected in their dress code, songs, drums, dances, cuisines and chants.

This drama skit by the Yorubas in Trinidad has not only announced their unity but has showcased their love for their culture. They have instituted a practice that their young ones and even generations to come will appreciate and identify with. There is no better way of cross-cultural fertilisation than showcasing your culture in an entirely different environment. As other cultures begin to experience and benefit from the rich cultural displays of the Yoruba people it is only natural to see them appreciate and imitate what has been seen.

Hausa Drama Skit: The story is on Aisha, a teenage girl who suffers parental abandonment because of her refusal to get married to Alhaji. Aisha wants to be an educated person but her parents plan for her is different. She repeatedly gets punished by her elder brothers for running away from Alhaji's house. Aisha makes several efforts to convince her family on her dream to be educated but all prove abortive. Thus, Aisha ends up taking her life to put an end to her misery.

This story engages an aspect of Hausa Culture of early child marriage. It is a cultural practice from time in memorial, believed to be ideal by the people of that culture. A practice that has faced criticism but significantly reveals their uniqueness. This cultural element has been integrated in performance for all to see simply because of the accessibility of social media platforms. It is their way of life, their tradition which they are proud of, and it is an indication that it has to be respected by all.

Igbo Drama Skit: The performance is titled “Nma Oha” it is an Igbo cultural drama. It dramatise the cultural heritages and tradition of the Igbo people through storytelling, dance, costumes and masquerade performance. This was done by the Igbos in Abuja to keep in touch with their root and remind them of the essentiality of their culture; especially the young ones who haven't had the privilege of going to the east. It showcases the distinctive culture of the people, their shared views and activities. The Igbos has a unique way of announcing their presence wherever they find themselves, and their culture is instrumental to that. Today, society is in tune with their culture and activities, mostly because of the electronic media. Their story is popular in Nollywood and on various social media platforms. One does not need to visit the east before been abreast with their activities.

Through the new media these different cultural groups have directly portray their stories and traditional practices to encourage intercultural communications. Just a click on the phone and cultural diversity is displayed in different forms. Various performances of dance, songs, dress styles, acts of worship, marriage and other essential aspects of traditions of the Ijaws, Yorubas, Hausa and the Igbos are learnt by people from other parts of the world. Some of such performances now have a blend of cultural displays from these various ethnic groups; to create a unique performance style, because of availability of information on the social media. Thus, it they serve as mechanisms to promote intercultural harmony, respect for others culture and cross-cultural exchange globally.

Conclusion

During the lockdown period caused by the COVID-19 global pandemic, online content flourished and gained prominence with several themes, some of which were cultural specific to

promote learning and awareness. Up till date, the social media is the cultural centre of the world. Daily, performances of indigenous culture which satisfy the cultural and artistic needs of society in the 21st century are seen. This paper discusses online content as veritable resources for cross cultural exchange in Nigeria and the world beyond. It takes into consideration selected online skits from four regions in Nigeria to establish the crux of this discourse. Interestingly, the study reveals the effectiveness of online theatre in promoting harmony and global solidarity.

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